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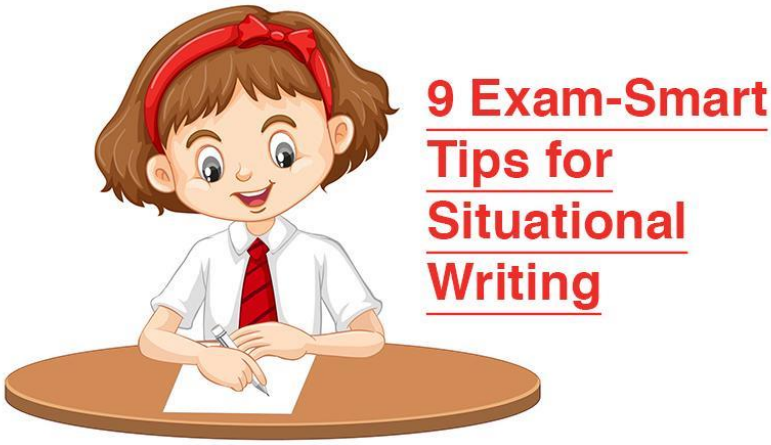
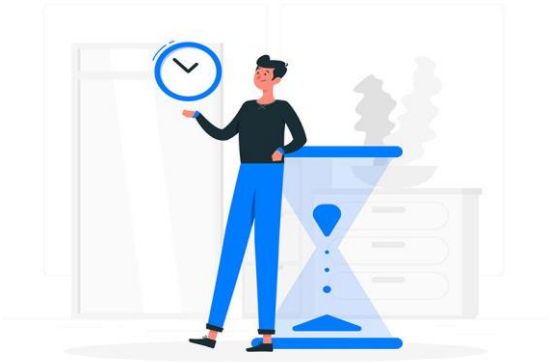


9 Exam-Smart Tips for Situational Writing

English Paper 1 is made up of two parts – Situational Writing (SW) and Continuous Writing. Both parts are equally important, but a lot of students find Situational Writing easier and put less effort in practising it. That's a mistake! If it is easier to score well in Situational Writing, then students should always aim to get 15 out of 15 marks for it.

That said, there are simple tips to follow to write a good piece of Situational Writing; and the more you practise, the easier it gets. Read on for more exam-smart Situational Writing tips to help you nab those 15 marks.



1. 15 Minutes Maximum!

The duration for Paper 1 is 1 hour and 10 minutes. Do not spend more than **15 minutes** on the Situational Writing section. Every student needs at least 55 minutes for their compo planning and writing. (And yes, you **must** plan for your compo!)

Spend 5 minutes planning for your Situational Writing and the remaining 10 minutes writing. If you have a clear idea of the points you need to include and the language you need to use, you should be able to finish it in 20 minutes or less.

2. Purpose, Audience, Context (PAC)

Read the question carefully. You will gather 3 very important pieces of information from the task.

- The **purpose** of writing **(P)**
- The **audience** to whom you are writing **(A)**
- The **context** you are writing in **(C)**

The Situational Writing question will normally ask you to write an email or a letter. Less common Situational Writing tasks would be to write a report, a notice or a postcard. You should practise writing letters and emails more but don't panic if your exam turns out to be a report, notice or postcard. Just remember, they all require PAC. Once you have correctly determined the PAC from the question or task, you will do just fine.

In your exam, you should highlight or underline the PAC as you are reading the task. Let's take a look at an example and pick out the PAC.

Your task

Imagine you are Isabella.

(A) ***(P)***

Write a letter to the Head Librarian of Good City Library to tell him about what you saw four boys from Smart Primary School did at the library.

You are to refer to the given pictures and information for your letter.

Purpose: "to tell him about what you saw the four boys from Smart Primary School did at the library"

Audience: "the Head Librarian of Good City Library"

Context: Formal, tone of a primary school student speaking to an adult

3. Salutations

As you know, Situationl Writing always starts with a salutation. You use either 'dear' or 'hi', depending on the Audience and the Context. As you are identifying the Audience and Context from the task, make a note of which salutation you should use. Do this so you can save time for writing. Let's take a look at the example again and write down the salutation above the Audience.

Your task

Imagine you are Isabella.

(Dear Head Librarian,)

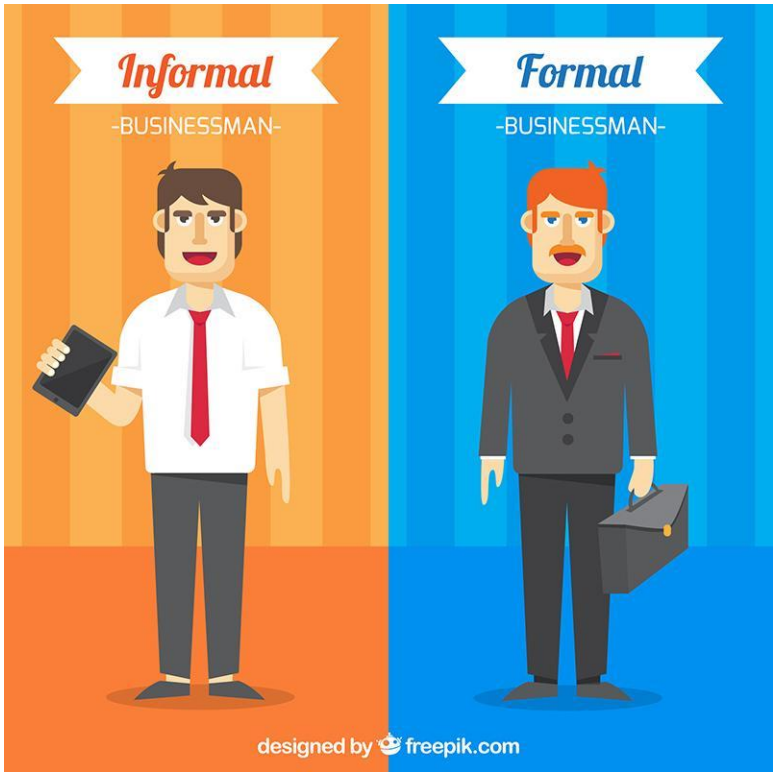
Write a letter to the Head Librarian of Good City Library to tell him about what you saw the four boys from Smart Primary School did at the library.

You are to refer to the given pictures and information for your letter.

Here's a table to show you which salutation to use:

Context	Greeting	How to address Audience?			Example
Formal	Dear	I know their name	→	By their name	Dear Ms Quek,
		I don't know their name	→	Sir / Madam / "Designation" / Group name	Dear Sir, Dear Madam, Dear Head Librarian, Dear Residents,
Informal	Dear	By their name			Dear Aunt Cherry,
	Hi				Hi Aunt Cherry,

To be exam smart, try not to use any 'creative' greetings. They will not give you more marks. Simply use 'dear' or 'hi'. Keep it simple!



4. The Tone Depends on Context

Students normally have difficulty writing in an accurate tone and which tone to use depends on the Context.

When the task requires you to write to a person of higher authority, or someone you are not close to, your tone has to be polite as you are writing in a formal context. When requesting

something from the reader, you can be persuasive but not demanding. Instead of writing, "You need to tell the students to keep quiet in the library," you should write, "I hope you will remind the students to be quiet in the library." Add **"I hope you will…"** in front of your request and do not bring strong emotions into it. In formal writing, you mustn't lecture your reader, you are merely reminding them politely.

- I hope you will give us permission to…
- I hope you will improve the customer service…
- I hope you will remind your students…
- I hope you will understand that…

In the informal context, you should use more relaxed language. When requesting something from the reader, you can be direct about it. Instead of writing, "I would greatly appreciate it if you could show up," you can write, "Do join us if you can!" Also, try **turning your requests into questions**. It will instantly make your writing more casual.

- Will you be able to join us on that day? Hope to hear from you soon!
- Are you interested? Let me know as soon as you can!
- Get well soon, okay?

Do not write 'I am writing to tell you…' in the introduction for informal text. It is too formal. Instead, make it casual by telling them what happened recently or what you saw recently, followed by an emotion attached to the Purpose for writing.

Task: Imagine you are Alex. Write a letter to Aunt Karen to tell her about your new pet rabbit. Hi, Aunt Karen, How are you? My parents recently bought me a pet rabbit and I am excited to tell you all about it!

Even though the Audience is an adult (an Aunt), the tone can be informal because they are close relatives.

Task: Imagine you are Alex. Write an email to your friend, Gerald, to encourage him to join the baking competition.

Hi, Gerald!

How are you? Recently, I saw a poster about a baking competition, and I am excited to tell you about it since you are the best baker I know. Maybe after reading my email, you will be interested to join the competition!

5. Task Fulfilment

Out of the 15 marks for Situational Writing, 6 marks are allocated for Task Fulfilment. Task Fulfilment marks are given when your Situational Writing has all the information the bullet points are asking for. Sometimes, the task will provide 5 bullet points but there will **always be 6 key pieces of information** that you need to include in your writing.

As you read the bullet points, put a number (1 – 6) to each point to make sure you have identified 6 points in total. Here's an example:

In your letter, include the following information:

(1) *(2)*
- where and when the incident happened

(3)
- what the students were doing

(4)
- what one of the students said to you

(5)
- what the students did after that

(6)
- the title of the book that the students vandalised

As you are studying the stimulus or the pictures, number the information that you need according to which task fulfilment point it is answering. For example, you would highlight the location and the time in the stimulus and put a **(1)** and **(2)** over that information respectively.

6. Follow the Order of the Bullet Points

The remaining 9 marks are allocated to Language and Organisation. Language refers to your punctuation, spelling, grammar, expression, and tone, while Organisation refers to the clarity in presenting your information. This tests the linking and sequencing of information in your Situational Writing.

You should present the information in your writing in the order of the bullet points shown in the question. This is the best way to make sure you don't miss out any of the points when you are writing, and the bullet points are arranged in that order to guide the sequence of your writing in the first place!

The order of the bullet points also helps you organise the information in a way that is easy to follow and understand. So try not to jumble up the order unless it is appropriate to do so. Let's look at the same example:

In your letter, include the following information:

(1) *(2)*
- where and when the incident happened

(3)
- what the students were doing

(4)
- what one of the students said to you

(5)
- what the students did after that

(6)
- the title of the book that the students vandalised

You can include the title of the book (point 6) when you are describing what the students were doing (point 3). Example:

> When I was at the Children's section at Good City Library **[point 1]** on 10 March 2020, four boys from Smart Primary School entered at 4 pm **[point 2]**. They immediately started making a lot of noise, so I decided to keep an eye on them. As I did so, I saw them vandalising a copy of the book titled 'The Adventures of Huckleberry Finn' **[point 6]**. They were drawing lines on the cover with a black marker pen **[point 3]**.

However, if you are not sure how to weave in a piece of information with another key point, then just leave the order of information as it is.

Remember to tick off the points when you are done with them. This helps you keep track of what you have already included and what you have yet to.

Answer the bullet points accurately, but also add **transition words -** (e.g, eventually, therefore, however) and **connectors** – (e.g but, and, so) when you are describing content. Such words that aid the flow of events. "*...so, I decided to,*" from the above example is a connector. It helps 'fill in the gap' in the sequence.

If the sentence did not have a connector it would end up like this: "*They immediately started making a lot of noise. I kept an eye on them.*" Although you are reporting what is happening accurately, there is a 'gap' in the sequence of events.

7. Do Not Make Things Up

Save your creative ideas for your compo. In Situational Writing, you can only use the information you are given.

Taking the above example, you are to write what the students were doing according to the information you have been given in the stimulus. If the picture shows the students drawing on the cover of the book with a black marker, you should write, “They were drawing lines on the cover with a black marker pen.”

Do **not** include details not shown in the picture. For example, “They were drawing lines on the cover, tearing pages out of the book and stomping on the torn-out pages.” You are just making information up.

However, there are two instances where you can make things up.

You **can** make up content when one of the bullet points asks you to provide a piece of information that isn’t in the stimulus. This is often “how you felt”. Of course, the content that

you come up with must also make sense. If the task is to write a complaint letter about the customer service, you cannot feel happy about the poor customer service.

Sometimes, the character drawn in the stimulus will have certain facial expressions. You cannot ignore that as well. You cannot say that you were pleased with the service when the picture shows your character being clearly annoyed.

You **can** also make up the names if the task and stimulus do not provide it. In formal Situational Writing, you will need a name to introduce yourself with, and you always need a name to sign off with. However, not all tasks will tell you what "your" name is. In this case, you should come up with a name or use your real name. (Please do not write funny sounding names in the exams…if not you will become the laughingstock when you lose your marks!)

8. Always Have a Conclusion

Many students make the mistake of signing off right after fulfilling all the bullet points. This makes the Situational Writing end abruptly and unnaturally. To avoid that, you need a conclusion. A simple conclusion would be to **state what you hope will be done**. Most of the time, this piece of information has to come from the Purpose.

Informal text example:

Purpose: To tell your Aunt Karen about the new pet rabbit your parents bought for you.
Ending: Do tell me about your first pet if you had one. Hope to hear from you soon!

Formal text example:

Purpose: To tell the Head Librarian about what you saw the four boys from Smart Primary School did at the library. **Ending:** I hope you will be able to identify the four students and remind them to treat library books with care and respect. Thank you.

For Situational Writing questions that have no requests for actions to be taken (for e.g., letter of commendation), simply restate your Purpose for writing.

Purpose: To tell the Principal of Success Primary School that one of his students did a kind deed. **Ending:** I have decided to write this letter to tell you about your student's kind deed and to show my appreciation for him.

9. Always Check Your Work

As always, check your work when you are done. Out of 15 marks, 9 marks are awarded for Language and Organisation. Students lose marks when it comes to Language because of errors in spelling, punctuation, or grammar. Do not let careless mistakes keep you from getting that 15/15.

Here is what you need to take note of when you are checking your work.

- Tenses

There may be a mixture of past, present and future tense for situational writing. Be mindful of the time frame! Use past tense only when you are describing past events.

- Avoid overly creative expressions

Do not use similes or metaphors.

- Capital letters

Names and titles should be capitalised. For e.g., Head Librarian, Principal, Sir, Madam, Mrs Khoo, Mr Sulaiman, Residents, All.

- Format of date and time

Months should be spelled out, and dates should be in the **DD MM YYYY** format. For e.g., 15 October 2019, 4 pm, or 4 o'clock in the afternoon.

- Avoid contractions unless in informal writing

- Format of salutations and sign off

Finally, here is a table to help you remember how to sign off for your Situational Writing.

Context	**Sign-off**			**Name**	**Example**
Formal	I **know** the reader's name	→	Yours sincerely,	Full name	Yours sincerely, Sharon Tan
	I **don't know** the reader's name	→	Yours faithfully,		Yours faithfully, Sharon Tan
	I have a designation	→	"Designation", "Organisation",		President, Hiking Club, Sharon Tan
Informal	Your "designation", Cheers, From,			First name	Your friend, Sharon Cheers, Sharon From, Sharon

Similar to salutations, using a unique, 'creative' sign-off won't give you more marks. If you are not confident in Situational Writing, stick with the plain and boring 'Yours sincerely,' and 'Yours faithfully,' for formal writing and 'Cheers,' or 'From' for informal writing.

Final Words

Unlike compo writing, Situational Writing will definitely be applicable to your life in the future. In workplaces, requests and reports are frequently written and sent to your bosses and counterparts. So, it is useful to master Situational Writing skills now.

Keep on practising diligently and soon, scoring full marks for the Paper 1 Situational Writing segment will become a reality!

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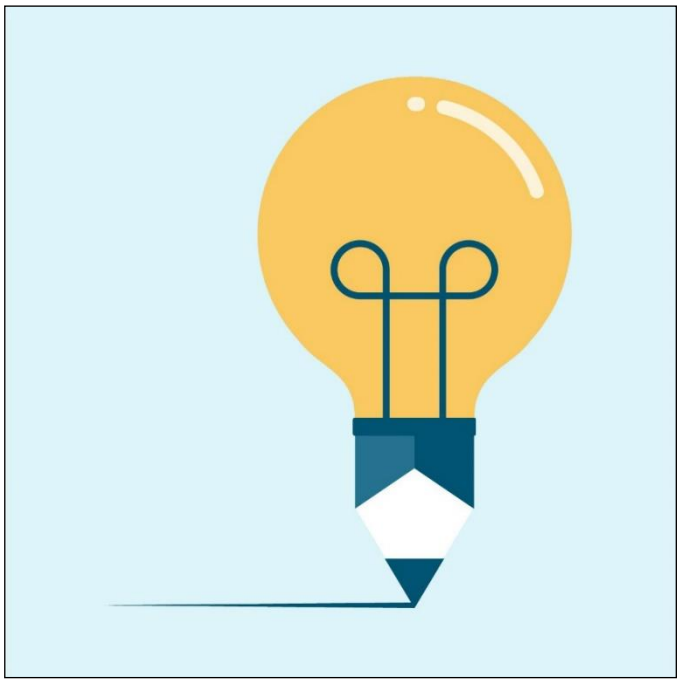

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